

MMS was originally developed within the Third-Generation Partnership Program (3GPP), a standards organisation focused on standards for the UMTS/GSM networks. Since then, MMS has been deployed worldwide and across both GSM/GPRS and CDMA networks. MMS has also been standardised within the Third-Generation Partnership Program 2 (3GPP2), a standards organisation focused on specifications for the CDMA networks.

MMS faces a few challenges that aren't there for SMS:

Content adaptation: Multimedia content created by one brand of MMS phone may not be entirely compatible with the capabilities of the recipient's MMS phone. In the MMS architecture, the recipient MMSC is responsible for providing for content adaptation (e.g., image resizing, audio codec transcoding, etc.) if this feature is enabled by the mobile network operator. When a network operator supports content adaptation, its MMS subscribers enjoy compatibility with a larger network of MMS users than would otherwise be available.

Distribution lists: Current MMS specifications do not include distribution lists, and neither can the methods by which large numbers of recipients be conveniently addressed, particularly by content providers, called Value Added Service Providers (VASPs) in 3GPP. Since most SMSC vendors have adopted FTP as an *ad hoc* method by which large distribution lists are transferred to the SMSC prior to being used in a bulk-messaging SMS submission, it is expected that MMSC vendors will also likely adopt FTP.

Bulk messaging: The flow of peer-to-peer MMS messaging involves several over-the-air transactions that become inefficient when MMS is used to send messages to large numbers of subscribers, as is typically the case for VASPs. For example, when one MMS message is submitted to a very large number of recipients, it is possible to receive a 'delivery report' and 'read-reply report' for each and every recipient. Future MMS specification work is likely to optimise and reduce the transactional overhead for the bulk-messaging case.